

Chuck out candidates with criminal records and ensure **TRANSPARENCY IN FUNDING**. Cleanse politics of crime and money.

Crime and money make a heady cocktail in Parliament today. MPs wave wads of currency notes on television for bribes they receive, and others are flown in from various jails to vote on the trust motion. There are over 120 MPs in the Lok Sabha with criminal charges against them, which makes it nearly 20 per cent of the 543 MPs. Few are convicted, and cases drag on for years and decades. The Representation of People Act, 1951, says that anyone sentenced to two years or more in jail is disqualified from contesting elections but this does not apply to sitting MPs and MLAs and even the Act is silent about those undergoing trial. Fortunately, there lies a simple way out.

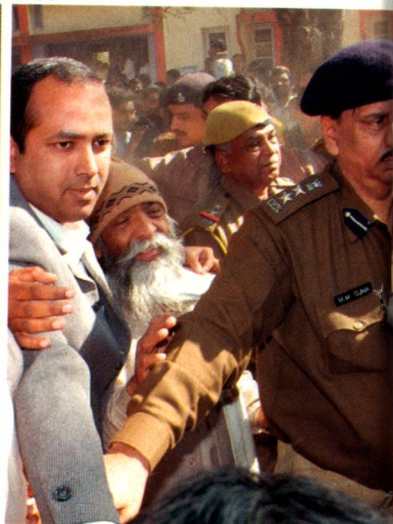
People with a minor criminal charge cannot be appointed even as Class IV employees in the government—even if they are not convicted as yet. However, one can become a chief minister, cabinet minister or even a prime minister while facing serious charges. If MPs are public servants, then they too should be debarred. In fact, this matter is pending before the courts. It will also provide the candidates with an incentive to get their cases disposed of on fast track.

One of the root causes of corruption in our society is the huge spending in elections. Money, liquor, clothes, television sets and all sorts of other goods are distributed to voters, in blatant violation of the law. The chief election commissioner recently wrote, "If a candidate is willing to spend 10 times more than the prescribed ceiling, it is not out of philanthropy, but in the secure knowledge that he can earn 10 times what he spends once he gets to the seat of power." A superficial analysis says that voters are getting smart—they take these freebies and vote for the candidate they like. However, the winning candidate's

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AP PHOTO



Crime and punishment:

Politicians who were imprisoned for criminal misconduct (clockwise from top left) Pappu Yadav, Shibu Soren and Jayalalithaa

focus is on recovering his or her investments and returning favours to those who provided funding. This is when we get bad governance. In urban areas, that means violation of all laws in the construction of apartments, shopping malls, water and sewerage pipes, roads and flyovers. In rural areas, it means violation